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EDCI 7334 — Week 1 Reflection

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What are Historical Curricular-Pedagogical Languages (CPP), and from these languages, what should we retain?

As someone with an engineering background, the experience of diving into the different Historical Curriculum-Pedagogical Languages was truly eye-opening. Schubert (1996) categorizes these as Intellectual Traditionalists, Social Behaviorists, Essentialists, and Critical Reconstructionists, personifying each one in an equally amusing yet profound "conversation" among these languages (p. 169). However, I recognize that my perspective may be somewhat limited by my background, particularly my focus on mathematics. It is also evident from his writings that there are inherent tensions among these perspectives that have played out historically. I found these tensions also play out within me.

According to Schubert's personification of the Traditionalists, "[t]he best answers to the basic curriculum question (What is worth knowing?) are found in the great works and in the organized disciplines of knowledge." One such traditionalist was William Torrey Harris, who held the view that "the purpose of the school ... was to foster the development of reason in its highest sense. This entailed the imparting of universal ideas and principles instead of numerous isolated and unrelated facts" (Sniegoski, 1990, p. 8). As Schubert's personification mentions, Harris and his school of thought were more interested in the "transcendent matters of culture, race, gender, class, age, ethnicity, location, health or ableness, national origin." It is at this point that I found myself agreeing with Schubert's personification and asking myself: should mathematics truly not be taught as a way to elevate the human experience to the highest levels of reason? Should I not be relaying to my students that Pythagoras was on a quest to find the meaning of the universe in his pursuit of geometry at the time of his theorem? Again, limited by my lens in mathematics, I found myself agreeing with the statement, "to be a great teacher one must know and love one's subject. Too many teachers do not know or appreciate the depth and breadth of their subject, so how can we expect them to inspire others to immerse themselves in it?" (Schubert, 1990, p. 170).

Just like the criticism of Harris's time, I also had an internal struggle within me. What about practicality? Oftentimes in the classroom, I hear, "the way to engage students is to relate it to its use in the real world." I do not disagree, and I enjoyed seeing F. Bobbitt's strategy. In his view, representing the Social Behaviorist, curriculum and pedagogy should be useful in a practical way. He mentions going to the most productive farms and analyzing the most effective methods. The curriculum writer is to thoroughly study these methods and then return to the students with the objectives necessary to be successful in the particular field. Bobbitt writes,

> *"Whether in agriculture, building trades, housekeeping, commerce, civic regulation, sanitation, or any other, education presumes that the best that is practicable is what ought to be. Education is to keep its feet squarely upon the earth; but this does not require that it aim lower than the highest that is practicable."*

This was also evident in Harris's time, where there was an emphasis on the inclusion of manual and vocational training in schools. I agreed: what is the use of the pursuit of truth in mathematics if it is of no use to the carpenter, the welder, or the merchant? Perhaps this was why I was drawn to engineering as a subject. Suddenly, mathematics was more of a tool needed to construct the spaceship, the power plant, and the motors. Deep knowledge of mathematics had a purpose within the study of engineering, and it was not merely to elevate a few. Perhaps it is no coincidence that Texas A&M;, where I started my engineering studies, was originally an agricultural school. What then is my responsibility toward students who may merely think of education as a way to get a job? At what point does the study of mathematics stop being so grandiose and become practical? At what point is Pythagorean theorem about the quest for describing the universe around and more about building roofs that will pass the construction inspection? I started wondering, is there more to the TEKS than I initially thought?

Then as I read about the Experientialist or Progressives written by Oliva and Gordon (2019)

> *"To the progressives then, education is not a product to be learned-for example, facts and motor skills-but a process that continues as long as one lives. To their way of thinking a child learns best when actively experiencing his or her world, as opposed to passively absorbing preselected content. If experiences in school are designed to meet the needs and interests of individual learners, it follows that no single pattern of subject matter can be appropriate for all learners." (p. 133).*

The words passively absorbing caused much reflection. Students are, after all, people and the experience of learning is one that encompasses their entire being. Furthermore, the reconstructionist talk of the hidden curriculum caused me to reflect, how much am I instructing students with this hidden curriculum?

In considering these languages in the light of my teaching practice, I recognize the importance of having depth to the curriculum to bring to life ideals that we have set up as a society. From the Social Behaviorist, we should definitely emphasize the knowledge obtained as a means to usefulness, especially in an ever changing society. From the essentialists, we should recognize that students come with experiences to the classrooms that must be acknowledged and from the reconstructionist, I am reminded that there is always a hidden curriculum that I must be aware of and that I must provide equitable learning experiences to all my students.

References

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